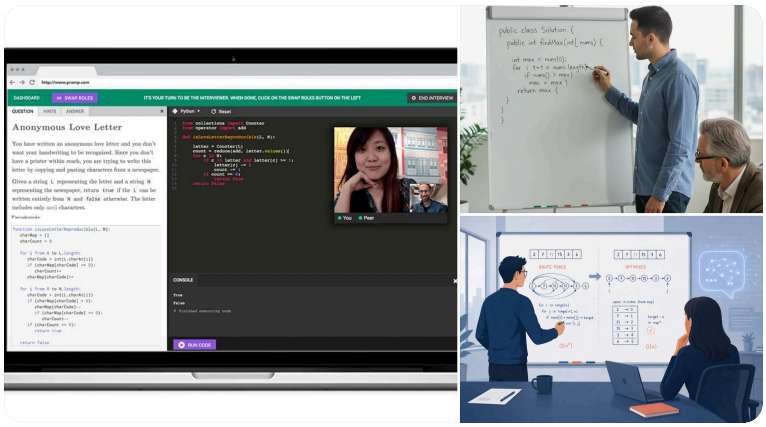
Hi ChatGPT. Actually I am from LTM company. From there I am working as vendor on HSBC. And currently my project, they are, because of some budget issue, they are releasing me from the project. 30th November is my last day, working day. So after that in L&T, there are four to five days bench period policy. After that they release. So I don't want to leave from the company. I want to get a different project. But for that take a different project. Nowadays they are taking the Karat exam. So in Karat most of the people are saying, learn DSA things and that things. But actually I don't know anything about the Karat exam. So could you please guide me? And what should I prepare for this? Because before the interview nowadays they are taking Karat exam for the banking domain. So please guide me in depth.

First of all, don't panic. Your situation is understandable. You are working at LTM (L&T Technology Services/LTIMindtree, depending on your employer entity) as a vendor on the HSBC project. Because of budget constraints, your release date from the project is **30 November 2026**. You want to continue with your current company by getting allocated to another project rather than leaving the organization.

My recommendation is to prepare for the Karat assessment in a structured way, while also preparing for the technical interviews that follow it. You do not need to become an expert in every DSA topic before you can start.

Since your background is in Java and enterprise banking applications, we can build your preparation around **Java coding, problem-solving, SQL, Spring Boot, microservices, Kafka, and banking-domain scenarios**.

1. First, understand what the Karat exam is



Karat is a technical interview and engineering assessment platform used by companies to evaluate candidates' coding and problem-solving skills. Depending on the employer and assessment setup, it can involve a live technical interview, coding exercises, technical questions, or a combination of these.

The important point: Karat is a platform, not one standardized exam. The exact questions, duration, programming language, difficulty, and scoring criteria depend on the assessment arranged by your employer or the hiring team.

For your internal project allocation, we should establish whether LTM uses a standard Karat coding interview, a customized Java assessment, or a banking-project-specific evaluation. I cannot confirm your company's exact assessment format without that information.

What might they evaluate?

Area	What you should be able to do
Java coding	Write working code and explain your logic
DSA	Solve arrays, strings, hash maps, sorting, and related problems
Problem-solving	Break a problem into steps and handle edge cases
Java fundamentals	Collections, exceptions, streams, OOP, and concurrency
SQL	Write joins, grouping, filtering, and analytical queries
Backend development	Explain Spring Boot, REST APIs, transactions, and microservices
Communication	Explain your approach, test your code, and discuss complexity

Not every assessment will cover every area. We will prioritize based on the actual role.

2. How does a Karat interview actually work?

According to Karat's candidate guidance, many interviews last approximately 45–60 minutes and combine a discussion section with coding questions. One published example uses about 10 minutes for technical discussion and 45 minutes for coding; other formats vary by role.

Karat +1

A possible format looks like this:

Stage 1 — Introduction and project discussion

Around 5–10 minutes in some formats

Explain your experience, your HSBC project, your responsibilities, and a technical challenge you solved.

Stage 2 — Java coding and DSA

Usually a substantial part of the interview

Solve one or more programming problems. You may need to write, run, debug, and improve your code.

Stage 3 — Explanation and follow-up questions

Explain why your approach works, discuss edge cases, and analyze time and space complexity. The interviewer may ask you to extend your solution.

These are preparation expectations, not a guarantee of your specific LTM assessment structure. Karat's published evaluation criteria include solution completeness, independence, optimality, complexity analysis, and debugging.

Customer Op... +1

An important takeaway: Do not only memorize solutions. You must be able to write code yourself and explain it clearly.

3. Do you really need to learn DSA?

Yes, you should learn the fundamentals of Data Structures and Algorithms (DSA). However, you do not need to begin with advanced competitive programming.

For your Java backend experience, I recommend the following priority order.

Priority 1 — Must master

Arrays, strings, loops, hash maps, sets, sorting, searching, basic complexity analysis.

Start here

Priority 2 — Important

Two pointers, sliding window, stacks, queues, binary search, linked lists, recursion.

Priority 3 — Learn after the basics

Trees, binary search trees, heaps, BFS/DFS, basic graphs, introductory dynamic programming.

Do not spend your first week trying to solve difficult dynamic programming or graph problems. First become comfortable solving easy problems without looking at the answer.

Your first 15 Java coding problems

These are good starting exercises, not claims about questions that LTM or HSBC will ask.

No.	Problem	Main concept
1	Find the largest and second-largest distinct numbers	Arrays
2	Find duplicate elements	HashSet
3	Count the frequency of each element	HashMap
4	Reverse a string	Strings
5	Check whether a string is a palindrome	Two pointers
6	Check whether two strings are anagrams	Frequency counting
7	Find the first non-repeating character	LinkedHashMap or frequency array
8	Find the missing number from 1 to N	Array and arithmetic
9	Move all zeros to the end	Two pointers
10	Two Sum: find two numbers adding to a target	HashMap
11	Find a pair with a given sum in a sorted array	Two pointers
12	Perform binary search	Searching
13	Check balanced parentheses	Stack
14	Merge two sorted arrays	Two pointers
15	Find the longest substring without repeating characters	Sliding window

You have already been practicing questions such as finding the second-highest number and duplicates. Those are useful foundations. Now the goal is to move from explaining an approach verbally to writing correct Java code independently.

4. Your Java preparation roadmap

For a Java backend engineer, the assessment may emphasize DSA, while the subsequent project interview may focus more on Java, Spring Boot, SQL, microservices, and banking workflows. Prepare for both, but confirm the actual assessment scope with your internal recruiter.

Track A: Java coding and DSA

Study in this order:

1. Arrays and strings.
2. HashMap, HashSet, and frequency counting.
3. Sorting, searching, and Big-O notation.
4. Two pointers and sliding window.
5. Stack, queue, and linked list.
6. Recursion, trees, and basic graphs.
7. Mock coding interviews.

Track B: Core Java

Prepare to explain and demonstrate:

- OOP principles and SOLID fundamentals.
- `String`, `StringBuilder`, and string immutability.
- `equals()` and `hashCode()`.
- `HashMap` internals, hashing, collisions, and resizing.
- `ArrayList` versus `LinkedList`.
- Checked versus unchecked exceptions.
- Java 8+ streams, lambdas, `Optional`, and functional interfaces.
- Multithreading, synchronization, executor services, and concurrent collections.
- JVM memory, garbage collection, and common performance issues.

Track C: Spring Boot and enterprise backend

Focus on:

- Dependency injection and bean lifecycle.
- REST APIs, validation, and exception handling.
- Spring Data JPA and transaction management.
- Spring Security and authentication/authorization.
- Microservices communication and resilience.
- Unit testing with JUnit and Mockito.
- Logging, debugging, monitoring, and production troubleshooting.

Track D: SQL and banking systems

Practice SQL queries involving joins, `GROUP BY`, aggregate functions, subqueries, and window functions such as `ROW_NUMBER()`.

For banking applications, understand these concepts:

- Transaction consistency and database transactions.
- Idempotency and duplicate-request handling.
- Audit trails and access control.
- Retry strategies and failure handling.
- Reconciliation and transaction status tracking.
- Secure document access and authorization.

These topics are particularly relevant to enterprise banking backend work, but they are not necessarily part of the Karat coding section.

5. Your 32-day preparation plan: October 30 to November 30

Your project release date gives you a clear deadline. Today is October 29, so you have roughly one month to build your preparation routine before your last working day on November 30.

I recommend **2–3 hours per day on weekdays and 3–4 hours on weekends**, if your work schedule permits. Your immediate objective is to become interview-ready as quickly as possible, not to complete every DSA topic.

Daily preparation tracker

0 of 29 tasks completed

0%

Week 1 · Oct 30 – Nov 5

Java coding foundations

- [ ] Arrays and strings
- [ ] Second-largest number, duplicates, frequency counting
- [ ] Reverse string, palindrome, anagrams
- [ ] HashMap, HashSet, equals() and hashCode()
- [ ] Solve 10–12 easy coding problems
- [ ] Explain Big-O: O(1), O(n), O(n log n), $O(n^2)$

Week 2 · Nov 6 – Nov 12

Common interview patterns

- [ ] Sorting and binary search
- [ ] Two pointers and sliding window
- [ ] Stack, queue, linked list basics
- [ ] Solve 10–12 easy-to-medium problems
- [ ] Practice writing code without IDE autocomplete
- [ ] Complete one timed mock interview

Week 3 · Nov 13 – Nov 19

Core Java and backend

- [ ] Java collections, streams, exceptions and concurrency
- [ ] Spring Boot, REST APIs and validation
- [ ] SQL joins, grouping and window functions
- [ ] Transactions, idempotency and microservices
- [ ] Practice explaining your HSBC project
- [ ] Complete two timed coding mocks

Week 4 · Nov 20 – Nov 26

Assessment readiness

- [ ] Revise weak DSA patterns
- [ ] Trees and recursion fundamentals
- [ ] Review Kafka, retries and failure handling if relevant to the role
- [ ] Solve mixed problems under time limits
- [ ] Practice Java, SQL and project questions
- [ ] Complete two or three mock interviews

Final days · Nov 27 – Nov 30

Allocation and interview readiness

- ○ Revise your coding templates and common mistakes
- ○ Practice a full mock interview
- ○ Prepare a concise project introduction
- ○ Follow up with internal resource management and recruiters
- ○ Confirm your assessment format and next interview dates

If your assessment is scheduled before November 30, move the relevant mock interviews and revision tasks forward. You should not wait until your final working week to begin applying for other projects.

6. How to solve a coding question in the interview

This is one of the most important skills to practice.

Suppose the interviewer asks:

"Find the second-highest distinct number in an integer array."

For example:

```
int[] numbers = {10, 5, 20, 20, 8};
```

The expected answer is `10`, because the highest distinct number is `20` and the second-highest distinct number is `10`.

Here is a simple solution you should learn to explain:

```
public class SecondHighest {

    public static Integer findSecondHighest(int[] numbers) {
        Integer largest = null;
        Integer secondLargest = null;

        for (int number : numbers) {
            if (largest == null || number > largest) {
                secondLargest = largest;
                largest = number;
            } else if (number < largest &&
                       (secondLargest == null ||
                        number > secondLargest)) {
                secondLargest = number;
            }
        }

        return secondLargest;
    }

    public static void main(String[] args) {
        int[] numbers = {10, 5, 20, 20, 8};
        System.out.println(findSecondHighest(numbers));
    }
}
```

Output:

```
10
```

How to explain it to the interviewer:

1. I maintain two variables: the largest and second-largest distinct values.
2. When I find a new largest number, the previous largest becomes the second-largest.
3. Otherwise, I update the second-largest when I find a distinct value between the two.
4. Duplicate maximum values do not change the second-largest value.
5. If the array has fewer than two distinct numbers, the method returns `null`.

Complexity:

- Time: $O(n)$, because we traverse the array once.
- Auxiliary space: $O(1)$, because we use a constant number of variables.

Follow-up questions you should expect

The interviewer might ask:

- What if the array is empty?
- What if every number is the same?
- What if the numbers are negative?
- Can you solve it without sorting?
- What is the difference between $O(n)$ and $O(n \log n)$?

This is the type of thinking you need to practice across the other 14 problems as well.

Karat's published candidate guidance recommends practicing under realistic time constraints, communicating your reasoning, and analyzing complexity.

communicati... +1

7. How to practice every day

Use this routine for each two-hour study session.

20 min	**Learn the concept** Read the explanation and understand when the data structure or algorithm is useful.
50 min	**Write Java code** Solve two problems yourself. Do not copy the solution before trying.
25 min	**Test and explain** Run examples, test edge cases, and speak through the algorithm as if an interviewer were listening.
25 min	**Revise** Review one Core Java or Spring Boot topic and note mistakes from today's coding problems.

For practice, use LeetCode (problem set ↗), especially its easy and selected medium problems. Use HackerRank (Java practice ↗) for additional Java exercises. Prioritize solving problems yourself over collecting a large number of solutions.

8. Prepare for the banking-domain technical interview

After the coding assessment, a project discussion may evaluate whether you can contribute to the available team.

Prepare a two-minute introduction covering:

- Your Java backend experience.
- Your current HSBC project and the business purpose of the eShare Admin application.
- The services, APIs, databases, and frameworks you personally worked with.
- One challenging technical issue you resolved.
- How you handled security, permissions, testing, and production issues, where applicable.

Be specific about what you actually implemented; do not claim responsibilities you did not have.

Also prepare these scenario questions:

Question	What to cover
How would you prevent a duplicate banking transaction?	Idempotency, unique request keys, database constraints and transaction boundaries
How would you handle a temporary downstream service failure?	Timeouts, bounded retries, exponential backoff and circuit breakers
How would you process a Kafka message more than once?	Idempotent processing, deduplication and offset/commit strategy
How would you secure confidential documents?	Authentication, authorization, least privilege and audit logs
How would you investigate a slow API?	Logs, metrics, traces, SQL query analysis and profiling

These are representative backend interview scenarios, not confirmed Karat questions.

9. Do these three things immediately at LTM

Your objective is not only to pass an exam. It is to secure another internal project before your release process advances.

1. **Contact your resource manager and delivery manager.** Tell them you want to continue within the organization and ask for upcoming Java backend, Spring Boot, microservices, Kafka, or banking opportunities.
2. **Ask for the exact assessment details.** Confirm the Karat format, duration, supported language, required topics, difficulty, and whether the assessment is common across projects or specific to the target role.
3. **Start internal project discussions now.** Do not wait until November 30 to begin networking or interview scheduling.

10. Let me customize your preparation

I can train you step by step, including explaining each DSA concept in simple language, giving Java coding exercises, reviewing your answers, and conducting mock interviews similar to a live technical assessment.

I need just three details to create the right plan for you.

Your Karat preparation profile

1. How many years of experience do you have?

- ○ 2–4 years
- ○ 5–8 years
- ○ 9+ years

2. How comfortable are you with Java coding?

- ○ I can write basic Java, but struggle with DSA
- ○ I am comfortable with Java but need DSA practice
- ○ I need to revise Java and coding basics
- ○ I am comfortable with both Java and DSA

3. Do you know the Karat assessment format?

- Live coding interview
- Online timed assessment
- Not sure yet

My suggestion is to start with arrays, strings, and HashMap problems, then gradually move toward timed mock interviews. You can improve substantially with consistent practice, and you should pursue internal project opportunities in parallel rather than relying on the assessment alone.